C. Preservation by Drying

Microorganisms need moisture to grow. When exposed to sunlight or subjected to dehydration, the moisture in the food is removed and the concentration of water is brought below a certain level. This prevents the growth of microorganisms and thereby spoilage of food. Food preservation by drying is one of the oldest methods practiced from ancient times. This method consists of exposing food to sunlight and air until the product is dry. It is a very useful and economical process.

Both the terms 'drying' and 'dehydration' mean the removal of water. Drying is used to remove moisture by the application of unconventional energy sources like sun and wind. Dehydration means the process of removal of moisture by the application of artificial heat under controlled conditions of temperature, humidity and air flow.

DO YOU KNOW?

Traditional methods of controlling food grain loss -

- Mixing of inert dust such as sand, clay and ash with the grain prevents the entry of insects.
- Mixing the powder of pungam, neem or nochi leaves with the grains in the ratio of 1:100 help to control the insects.

Treatment of Foods Before Drying

1. Selection and sorting for size, maturity and wholesomeness
2. Washing, especially fruits and vegetables
3. Peeling of fruits and vegetables by hand, machine or knife
4. Subdivision into halves, slices, shreds or cubes
5. Blanching or scalding of vegetables and some fruits like tomatoes and peaches
6. Sulphuring of light coloured fruits and vegetables by exposure to sulphur-di-oxide gas.

ii. Sun Drying: It is limited to regions with hot climates and dry atmosphere and to certain fruits such as raisins, prunes, figs, apricots, pears and peaches. It is a slow process. Many Indian foods are preserved by sun drying. Papads, vadams and vathals



▲ Plate 6.3 Sun Dried Brinjal



▲ Plate 6.4 Sun Dried Sundaikai

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